PUPPY HANDOUT

Housetraining your puppy

Accidents are information, not misbehaviour. Your puppy has a small bladder and hasn't yet learned where the toilet is. Your job is to prevent mistakes and make the right place the best place in the world.

1. WRITE IT DOWN

- Put a **written schedule** on the fridge: meals, toilet breaks, rest. Everyone in the house follows it.
- Keep an **elimination journal** for two weeks: time, place, what happened. Patterns show quickly.

2. WHEN TO GO OUT

- On waking, including after naps
- After meals and drinks
- After play
- Before bed, and in the night while very young
- Take water up about two hours before bedtime

Under 3 months bladder control is still developing; it improves a lot at 4–6 months. Small dogs have smaller bladders and feel the cold.

3. AT THE TOILET SPOT

1. Go to the **same spot**, on lead.
2. **Stay with your puppy.** You can only reward what you see.
3. Say **"go potty"** *just as* it begins to go.
4. **Reward straight away** with praise and a treat.
5. Then give **a few minutes of free play outside**. Only after that, go in.

> **Why the play matters:** going straight in teaches your puppy that going means the fun ends, so it holds on. Keep rewarding well past the first successes. A little of your puppy's own urine or poop left at the spot helps it choose that surface.

4. THE CRATE

- Big enough to stand, sit, turn and lie down, but not so big it can use one end as a toilet. Use a **divider** that moves as it grows.
- Dogs avoid soiling where they sleep. That is why it works.
- A **safe den, never a punishment.** Feed meals in it; give food-filled toys.
- Keep it in a central room so your puppy is part of the family.
- **Don't open the door while it whines.** Wait for a moment of quiet.
- When you can't watch, use the crate or **baby gates** to keep it in a small area you can see.

5. WHEN THERE'S AN ACCIDENT

- **No punishment.** No shouting, no rubbing a nose in it. It teaches your puppy to hide.
- Clean with an **enzymatic cleaner**. Ordinary cleaners leave a scent that invites a repeat.
- Carry a kit when out: enzymatic spray, bags, wipes.

6. WE ADVISE AGAINST

- **Pee pads and litter boxes.** They teach that indoors is acceptable, and a dog trained only on one may struggle to go elsewhere. Exceptions: small dogs with elderly or disabled owners, and flats (pads in a playpen for the first few months, then grass).
- **Dog doors** in the early weeks. You can't supervise or reward.
- **Tethering** to you or to furniture. Use a crate, or teach **"place"**: your puppy goes to a spot and stays until released.

7. A BELL ON THE DOOR

Only if you answer it **every single time**. Some dogs learn to ring it just to get outside to play.

8. COMMON PROBLEMS

- **Wees when greeting:** involuntary, usually outgrown. Stay calm, keep greetings quiet, and pet on the chest, not over the head.
- **Eats its own poop:** clean up straight away. Change diet only on your vet's advice.
- **Upset stomach:** stress, diet changes and treats. Avoid hot dogs (too salty); boiled unseasoned chicken, sparingly.
- **Marking:** behavioural (a new pet) or medical. Have the vet check.
- **Rescue or puppy-farm puppies:** often used to living in dirt. It takes longer. Be patient.

9. CALL YOUR VET IF

A dog that was reliably house-trained suddenly has accidents. It can mean a urinary infection, incontinence, a weak bladder or diabetes.